

History

Most of Briones Regional Park was once part of Rancho Boca de la Canada del Pinole, popularly known as Rancho San Felipe. In 1829, Felipe Briones built a home near what is now the Bear Creek entrance to the park, cultivating the land and raising cattle. In 1842 Felipe's widow, Maria Manuela Valencia Briones, petitioned Governor Alvarado for a grant to the land the family had occupied. The grant, covering three square leagues, was issued in June 1842. Later, much of the rancho was purchased by Simon and Elias Blum. In addition to Rancho San Felipe, the current park includes small portions of Rancho Cañada del Hambre y las Bolsas, and Rancho Acalanes.

In the 1850s and 1860s, Alhambra Valley was developed into rich orchards and vineyards. It became Contra Costa County's most important fruit growing area. Cattle grazing is also a major industry. Hay and grain have been produced in the valleys intermittently for some years, as well as truck crops.

In 1906, the People's Water Company began purchasing land in the San Pablo and Bear Creek areas for watershed lands. The East Bay Municipal Utility District acquired People's Water Company in 1916 and built San Pablo Dam in 1923. In 1957 Contra Costa County and EBMUD agreed to a land conveyance that established a large open space park in the Bear Creek watershed to be called Briones.



In 1964, when portions of Contra Costa County were annexed to the East Bay Regional Park District, the County and the Park District agreed to a transfer of county land to the Park District, with the District to carry out additional land acquisition. Since 1966, watershed lands and other acquisitions have combined to form today's parkland.

Identifying flowers, 1973

The Park Today

This park is a popular destination for many recreational activities:

Picnicking A number of first-come, first-served picnic sites with tables and barbecues are located at the Bear Creek Staging Area and the Alhambra Creek Staging Area. The park also has two larger, reservable group picnic areas at the Bear Creek Staging Area: Oak Grove (capacity 50), and Newt Hollow (capacity 150). Crow, (capacity 50), is located at the Alhambra Creek Staging Area.

Archery Range The Briones Archery Club range is accessible off the Crescent Ridge Trail from Briones' west-side Bear Creek Road entrance. For information, visit brionesarchery.org.

Group Camping The three group camping areas – Wee-Ta-Chi, Maud Whalen, and Homestead Valley – must be reserved at least five business days in advance.

Briones Special Management Area



The Briones Special Management Area is a 1,600-acre zone in the northeast part of Briones Regional Park that employs a variety of trail management strategies to

protect habitat, wildlife, and watersheds. Specific rules regulate trail use, such as hiking only, biking only, or hiking/biking only, and direction of travel. On weekends, trail access within the Special Management Area alternates between bicyclists and equestrians based on whether it's an even or an odd calendar day.

Visit ebparks.org/parks/briones/briones-special-management-area for more information.

Ours to Explore, Enjoy, and Protect

Please enjoy Regional Parks safely and help protect and preserve the parklands by following all park rules and regulations.

Safety

- Stay on trails. Taking shortcuts can be dangerous and causes erosion.
- Carry and drink plenty of water. Dehydration is a leading cause of injuries on the trail.
- Be prepared for sudden changes in weather conditions.
- Trails can be slippery, rocky and steep. Proceed carefully at your own risk.
- Keep the parks beautiful. Pack out what you pack in.
- Inform someone where you are going and when you will be back.
- Store our 24/7 Dispatch Center number on your mobile phone: Emergency 510-881-1121; Non-emergency 510-881-1833.

POLICE, FIRE, MEDICAL EMERGENCY 9-1-1
PARK POLICE (evenings/weekends) 510-881-1833
CAMPING RESERVATIONS 1-888-327-2757, option 2
PARK OFFICE..... 1-888-327-2757, option 3, ext. 4556

Rules

- Dogs must be leashed in parking lots, 200 feet from any trail or park entrance or as posted, in picnic areas, developed areas such as lawns and play fields, on some trails, and where grazing animals are present. Pets must be under voice control at all times. Clean up after your pet: bag it, bin it.
- Bicycles are permitted on designated trails only.
- Horses have the right-of-way on trails.
- State law requires all bicyclists under age 18 wear an approved helmet while riding on trails and roadways. Equestrians and bicyclists are also strongly encouraged to wear helmets at all times.
- The following are prohibited:
 - Wading and/or swimming in undesignated areas
 - Consuming alcohol in non-designated areas/parks
 - Feeding or approaching wildlife
 - Releasing animals into parklands
 - Causing damage to plants, geological or archaeological features
 - Smoking
 - Drones

Visitors are responsible for knowing and complying with park rules (Ordinance 38). See ebparks.org/rules.



Briones Regional Park
Alhambra Creek Staging Area
2537 Reliez Valley Road, Martinez, CA
Bear Creek Staging Area
1611 Bear Creek Road, Lafayette, CA

East Bay Regional Park District
2950 Peralta Oaks Court, Oakland, CA 94605
1-888-EBPARKS or 1-888-327-2757 (TRS 711)
ebparks.org

**Regional Parks Membership**
RECEIVE FREE DAY-USE PARKING,
SWIMMING, AND MORE. 510-544-2220
REGIONALPARKSFUNDATION.ORG

Briones
Regional Park
LAFAYETTE, MARTINEZ



Briones Regional Park

Year Opened: 1967 **Acres:** 6,256

Highlights: hiking, biking, horseback riding, bird watching, picnicking, archery range, group camping, wildflowers in season.

Did You Know: From 1,483-foot Briones Peak, hikers can enjoy 360-degree views of the California Delta, Mount Tamalpais, Mount Diablo, and Las Trampas Regional Wilderness. Also, Naturalist John Muir, a resident of nearby Martinez, hiked these hills in the late nineteenth century.

Fees: see ebparks.org/parks/briones



Marc Crumpler

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